Consequences of Eviction for Parenting and Non-parenting College Students

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Abstract

Amidst rising and increasingly unaffordable rents, 7.6 million people are threatened with eviction each year across the United States—and eviction rates are twice as high for renters with children. One important and neglected population who may experience unique levels of housing insecurity is college students, especially given that one in five college students are parents. In this study, we link 11.9 million student records to eviction filings from housing courts, demographic characteristics reported in decennial census and survey data, incomes reported on tax returns by students and their parents, and dates of birth and death from the Social Security Administration. Parenting students are more likely than non-parenting students to identify as female (62.81% vs. 55.94%) and Black (19.66% vs. 14.30%), be over 30 years old (42.73% vs. 20.25%), and have parents with lower household incomes ($100,000 vs. $140,000). Parenting students threatened with eviction (i.e., had an eviction filed against them) are much more likely than non-threatened parenting students to identify as female (81.18% vs. 62.81%) and Black (56.84% vs. 19.66%). In models adjusted for individual and institutional characteristics, we find that being threatened with an eviction was significantly associated with reduced likelihood of degree completion, reduced post-enrollment income, reduced likelihood of being married post-enrollment, and increased post-enrollment mortality. Among parenting students, 38.38% (95% confidence interval (CI): 32.50-44.26%) of non-threatened students completed a bachelor's degree compared to just 15.36% (CI: 11.61-19.11%) of students threatened with eviction. Our findings highlight the long-term economic and health impacts of housing insecurity during college, especially for parenting students. Housing stability for parenting students may have substantial multigenerational benefits for economic mobility and population health.

[*] Disclaimer: Any opinions and conclusions expressed herein are those of the authors and do not represent the views of the US Census Bureau. The Census Bureau has ensured appropriate access and use of confidential data and has reviewed these results for disclosure avoidance protection (Project P-7516612: CBDRB-FY25-CES004-009). Data Sharing Statement: All our empirical results use confidential microdata from the US Census Bureau. We will not be able to make the data directly available. However, we can provide the code, and researchers can follow the directions on how to write a proposal to gain access to the data via a Federal Statistical Research Data Center using the standard application process.

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Introduction

Roughly 2.7 million renter households have an eviction filed against them each year, a population we refer to as those *threatened* with eviction (Gromis et al. 2022). Still, we know little about the characteristics of individuals living in these households. Documents from courts only record the names of the individuals listed on the lease and their address. Graetz et al. (2023) linked names and addresses from court filings to demographic data and household rosters[1], finding the eviction filing rate for adults living with a child was 10.4%, over double the risk for adults living without children (5.0%) (Graetz et al. 2023). The authors also documented stark racial disparities in filing rates; the annual eviction filing rates against Black adult renters living with children surpass 25%, well over double the risk faced by members of any other group.

Still, more work is needed to explore variation in eviction risk and its impacts across specific types of households—especially those with children. One important and neglected population who may experience unique levels of housing insecurity is college students. This population includes low-income individuals and landlords of rental housing near campuses may be relatively quick to file for evictions given the high turnover of students. Further, student parents—approximately one in five students—experience additional financial difficulties such as securing increasingly unaffordable childcare (Cameron et al. 2023). Combined with the increasingly high cost of rental housing (Airgood-Obrycki, Hermann, and Wedeen 2021; Joint Center for Housing Studies 2024), student parents may be at a particularly increased risk of eviction. Beyond the typical consequences of eviction, eviction among student parents may have intergenerational consequences by reducing the likelihood of the parent completing college.

The study of housing insecurity and its consequences among college students has been hampered by substantial data limitations, especially the availability of linked data that connect markers of housing insecurity with student enrollment records and postgraduate outcomes. In the present study, we created a new linked administrative dataset to examine the consequences of eviction among college students.

Data and Methods

Student records

We observe the full population of students in select university systems covering roughly the period 2001-2022 using Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO) (U.S. Census Bureau 2025). The PSEO are experimental linked microdata developed by researchers at the U.S. Census Bureau. PSEO data provides earnings and employment outcomes for college and university graduates by degree level, degree major, post-secondary institution, and state of institution. These statistics are generated by matching university transcript data with a national database of jobs, using state-of-the-art confidentiality protection mechanisms to protect the underlying data. The PSEO are made possible through data sharing partnerships between universities, university systems, State

[1] All data were linked using anonymized identifiers within a Federal Statistical Research Data Center.

Departments of Education, State Labor Market Information offices, and the U.S. Census Bureau. PSEO data are available for post-secondary institutions whose transcript data have been made available to the Census Bureau through a data-sharing agreement.

Our sample is not representative of the national population of students for two reasons. First, the PSEO data does not cover all students; coverage of partner systems varies across states and some states, such as California and Florida, have no partner systems (U.S. Census Bureau 2025). Second, for states that do have partner systems in the PSEO, approval for data access is handled on a state-by-state basis. We submitted proposals to access PSEO for every state that has any partner system, except for states that have very low eviction data coverage or very low eviction rates (e.g., South Dakota). We obtained approval to access PSEO for the following states/systems: the Indiana Commission for Higher Education (public 4-yr, 2-yr; 77% coverage of all graduates in the state), Iowa Board of Regents (U of Iowa, Iowa State, U of Northern Iowa) and Iowa Department of Education (Iowa Community Colleges) (66% coverage), Ohio Department of Higher Education (public 4-y, 2-yr; 61% coverage), Utah System of Higher Education (public 4-yr, 2-yr; 73% coverage), State Council of Higher Education for Virginia (public 4-yr, 2-yr, and some private; 87% coverage), and University of Wisconsin system (only UW campuses; 45% coverage).

Though our sample is unrepresentative and therefore our inferences cannot be generalized to the national student population, the PSEO represents one of the most comprehensive data efforts to date in linking students records to other census and administrative data sources. Students in the PSEO data have been assigned Protected Identification Keys (PIKs), which can be used to link individuals across sources. We merge by PIK to records in the 2000 Decennial Census, 2010 Decennial Census, and 2006-2023 American Community Survey (ACS) to observe student race, ethnicity, and sex. As we describe below, PIKs also enable us to link students to parenting status, eviction records, and income.

Parenting status

We merge by PIK and year to records in the Census Household Composition Key (CHCK). This file is created by the Census Bureau through several steps (Genadek, Sanders, and Stevenson 2022). Births are reported to state vital statistics offices and selected information from the birth certificate (e.g., name, date of birth, place of birth, mother's name, mother's SSN, father's name and father's SSN) are then shared with SSA for the purpose of assigning the child an SSN. The Census Bureau receives a subset of this data from SSA on a quarterly basis and uses the PVS system to assign PIKs to the parents on every child's SSN application based on names and addresses. The final CHCK file includes all parent-child PIK dyads by year for every child that is assigned an SSN at birth (95%) (Genadek et al. 2022). We use these year-specific dyads to categorize every student in our sample as "parenting" or "non-parenting" based on whether we observe the birth of a child in the CHCK prior to the first year of enrollment; for example, if a student is enrolled in 2012 and we see they had a child in the CHCK in 2008, we categorize that student as "parenting[2]." It is important to note that

[2] The CHCK file covers all children assigned an SSN at birth beginning in 1997. Because the PSEO data begins in 2001, it is possible we will incorrectly categorize some student parents as "non-parenting" if they had a child while enrolled

in using information from birth certificates in this way to proxy for parenting status at later dates, we do not directly observe the child living with the parent while they are enrolled; for example, it is possible that the student is divorced, and a different parent has custody of the child during the time they are enrolled. Despite this limitation, the CHCK represents a nearly complete administrative data source for the population that can be used to categorize virtually all students in our sample as parenting and non-parenting.

Eviction records

We draw on court records compiled by the Eviction Lab at Princeton University. These records, comprising 73.2 million defendants from 2000-2018, were collected either manually or via bulk extracts from administrative data systems. They were cleaned, stripped of duplicate and commercial eviction cases, geocoded, and validated against publicly available data sources published by county and state court systems. We submitted these records to the U.S. Census Bureau's Person Identification Validation System (PVS), which then assigned PIKs using a probabilistic linkage between records based on names and addresses reported in eviction filings. These linked eviction data are described in detail elsewhere (Graetz et al. 2023).

Estimating the impacts of eviction filing

To construct a sample for estimating the impacts of eviction on non-parenting and parenting students, we linked individuals across data sources using PIKs (Figure 1). In the PSEO, we observe enrollment and degree completion by institution and year. We focus on two binary outcomes from the PSEO data: completing at least an associate's degree and completing at least a bachelor's degree. We merge by PIK to records in the Numident file to observe dates of birth/death and use this to create one binary outcome: death within 10 years of the final year of enrollment. Finally, we merge by PIK and year to W2s and 1040s to observe total household income (including spouses) and marital status for students 3-5 years after their final year of enrollment; for brevity, we refer to this period following the final year of enrollment as "post-grad" in reporting results, though it includes all students regardless of whether they completed a degree. To proxy the financial background of students in our sample, we also merge by PIK to records in the 2000 Decennial Census to link students to the PIKs of their coresident parents in 2000. We then use these PIKs to merge parent incomes observed 0-5 years prior to their child's college enrollment.

We restrict our sample for analyses to only students for whom we can observe date of birth, race, ethnicity, and sex; we report descriptive summary statistics for this full sample. In our models, we use different subsets of this full sample depending on the completeness of the outcome variables. While we have virtually complete data on outcomes derived from PSEO and SSA data (associate's degree completion, bachelor's degree completion[3], and 10-year post-grad mortality), we have varying

who was born prior to 1997; however, this likely only affects a small minority of our total sample and any bias is unlikely to impact our final results.

[3] While we have complete degree completion information within systems, we only have access to a subset of systems nationwide; students may transfer out of a system we have access to into one that we do not. It is therefore possible we will incorrectly categorize some students as having not completed a degree, when in fact they transferred out of one of

levels of completeness for our outcome variables derived from tax data: 3-year post-grad marital status (31%), 5-year post-grad marital status (32%), 3-year post-grad joint income (31%), and 5-year post-grad joint income (32%). Further, in models where we control for the joint income of the parents of students measured within three years of student enrollment, we are only able to measure this for roughly half of students.

We estimate the effects of eviction filing and eviction judgment while enrolled (X_i) on our binary outcomes ($Y_{i,t,u}$) indexed by individual (i), year (t), and institution (u) using logistic regression:

$$\ln\left(\frac{Y_{i,t,u}}{1-Y_{i,t,u}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(X_{i,t} * P_i) + \boldsymbol{\beta_2 V_i} + \delta_u + \tau_t$$

Where P_i is parenting status, $\boldsymbol{V_i}$ is a vector of individual-level characteristics (age at enrollment, race, ethnicity, sex). We also include fixed effects for institution (δ_u) and enrollment year (τ_t). We fit these models using the R package *fixest* and report estimates for β_1. We also report marginal predictions averaged over the empirical distribution of all variables using the R package *marginaleffects*. To estimate the effects of eviction filing and eviction judgment while enrolled on our continuous outcomes, we use linear regression with the same specification of predictors described above.

In estimating the impacts of eviction filing, we do not find substantial differences in sample characteristics or estimated effects between groups filed against without receiving a judgment and those receiving a judgment. This is consistent with prior research using indicators derived from eviction court records and may be driven by the fact that filings alone are correlated with displacement regardless of the judgment status recorded in court records. In our main analyses, we focus on the total sample filed against and include results stratified by judgment status in the Appendix. We refer to students filed against for eviction as "threatened" and those not filed against as "non-threatened."

Results

Our sample consists of 11,891,000 students. Non-parenting and parenting students differ in terms of sociodemographic characteristics and outcomes (Table 1). Among students not threatened with eviction, parenting students are more likely than non-parenting students to be female (62.81% vs. 55.94%), over 30 years old (42.73% vs. 20.25%), identify as Black (19.66% vs. 14.30%), and come from lower-income families (average parental income of $100,000 vs. $140,000).

Compared to non-threatened parenting students, threatened parenting students are much more likely to identify as female (81.18% vs. 62.81%) and Black (56.84% vs. 19.66%). This pattern is also true among non-parenting students: threatened non-parenting students were also more likely to be

our systems and completed a degree in a system for which we do not have data. This bias will create somewhat deflated estimates of completion rates, perhaps more so for groups affected by eviction. When we refer to "reduced likelihood of degree completion," for example, we are including transfers out of the data systems for which we have access.

female and Black compared to their non-threatened peers. However, threatened non-parenting students tend to be relatively older (e.g., 25.67% were older than 35) whereas threatened parenting students tend to be relatively younger (e.g., 43.94% were 18-24).

In models controlling for individual and institutional characteristics, we find that being threatened with an eviction is significantly associated with lower likelihood of degree completion, lower post-grad income, lower likelihood of being married post-grad, and higher post-grad mortality (Table 2). With the exception of post-grad mortality, we also find that these associations are significantly larger for parenting students. These interactions, except for that of post-grad joint income, remain significant in models additionally controlling for parental income measured three years prior to enrollment.

For ease of interpretation, we use the models that include parental income to estimate marginal means for all outcomes stratified by parenting and filing status (Figure 2). Among non-parenting students, 53.26% (48.91-57.61%) of non-threatened students complete a bachelor's degree compared to just 29.74% (24.71%-34.78%) of threatened students. Among parenting students, 38.38% (32.50-44.26%) of non-threatened students complete a bachelor's degree compared to just 15.36% (11.61%-19.11%) of threatened students.

Non-threatened parenting students have joint income five years post-grad ($126,000; $115,000-$137,000) comparable to that of non-threatened non-parenting students ($136,000; $127,000-$146,000). In contrast, joint income for threatened parenting students is substantially lower, at just $59,000 ($49,000-$69,000). Among parenting students, 65.38% (61.27%-69.48%) of non-threatened students are married five years post-grad compared to 26.45% (22.78%-30.11%) of threatened students. The mortality rate 10-years post-grad is 290 (200-380) per 100,000 for threatened parenting students compared to 140 (110-160) for non-threatened parenting students; in other words, an eviction filing is associated with a 107% increase in risk of death over the next ten years.

We also examine heterogeneity in these associations by age, sex, and race/ethnicity for parenting students by including three-way interactions with parenting and eviction status. We do not find significant interactions between being threatened with eviction and sex or race/ethnicity. However, we find significant and substantial interactions between being threatened with eviction and age, particularly with respect to joint income. Figure 4 illustrates these interaction effects from models stratified by student age group. We find that the average association between filing and joint income is driven by the relatively large associations between filing and reduced incomes for parenting students above age 30. Among parenting students over the age of 35, being threatened with eviction is associated with a $44,000 ($29,000-$59,000) reduction in post-grad joint income.

Conclusions

In this study, we used linked administrative data to examine the consequences of eviction among college students. By examining degree completion, post-graduate household income, and post-graduate mortality rates, our findings highlight the long-term economic and health impacts of

housing insecurity during college, especially for parenting students. Our study makes two important descriptive contributions.

First, we document that the threat of eviction while enrolled is heavily concentrated among Black women. In our sample of parenting students linked to eviction filings, 81% were women despite women representing only 63% of all parenting students. Racial disparities were even more stark; Black students represent 57% of parenting students threatened with eviction despite representing just 20% of all parenting students. These disparities are similar to those documented in the general population (Graetz et al. 2023), suggesting colleges—at least among institutions covered by our sample—are not currently providing significant protection or disruption of the broader racialized dynamics of housing insecurity for women living with children in the general rental market.

Second, we find that between being threatened with eviction is significantly associated with lower likelihood of degree completion, reductions in post-graduate income, and higher likelihood of death within 10 years of graduation. Further, we find that while parenting students tend to be married at higher rates within five years of graduation than non-parenting students (65% vs. 51%), the opposite is true among students threatened by eviction: 33% of non-parenting students threatened with eviction are married compared to 26% of parenting students threatened with eviction. This substantial gap suggests that the threat of eviction may be associated with relationship dissolution, but more likely that the threat of eviction is heavily concentrated among single parenting students. Access to stable housing may be particularly beneficial for single parenting students.

This study has several important limitations. Our sample is not representative of the national student population for several reasons. First, we were only able to obtain approval to access student records in the PSEO data for a subset of geographies: The City University of New York (CUNY), Indiana, Iowa, Ohio, Utah, Virginia, Wisconsin. Second, linkage to eviction records is incomplete due to varying levels of completeness in the eviction data across time and space and imperfect PIK match rates. We also note that while the interaction effect of parenting and filing status is significant for most outcomes, these interactions are not always robust to the inclusion of parental income (e.g., post-grad income). It is difficult to determine whether this is truly driven by confounding associated with parent income or the fact that our sample size is significantly reduced when we subset to students for whom we can measure parental income. Future work should further explore the economic background of parenting students and its intersection with both risk of eviction and the consequences of eviction on postgraduate outcomes.

Our study adds to a growing body of research demonstrating that stable housing is a critical condition for student success—especially given that one in five undergraduates in the United States are parenting students. Our findings also have important implications for colleges seeking to design programs that maximize retention and completion for parenting students. Housing is often not well accounted for when colleges are assessing the average cost of attendance for students and is likely most challenging for single parenting students. Our study suggests that investing in housing stability for these students may have substantial downstream economic impacts.

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Table 1. Sample characteristics of linked PSEO students.

	Non-parenting students			Parenting student		
	Not filed	**Filed**	**Evicted**	**Not filed**	**Filed**	**Evicted**
Female (%)	55.94	66.75	66.13	62.81	81.18	81.51
Age						
16-24	69.00	45.98	47.46	32.05	43.94	45.64
25-29	10.75	16.07	15.64	25.22	26.69	26.77
30-34	5.37	12.27	11.96	20.91	16.94	16.34
>35	14.88	25.67	24.94	21.82	12.43	11.25
Race (%)						
White	74.93	35.43	37.15	70.64	35.08	37.43
Black	14.30	54.81	55.78	19.66	56.84	56.26
Asian	10.38	8.77	6.14	9.24	7.29	5.57
AIAN	0.27	0.61	0.60	0.33	0.51	0.50
Other race reported	0.12	0.38	0.33	0.13	0.27	0.25
Ethnicity (%)						
Hispanic	6.39	9.75	6.14	7.68	8.39	5.90
Outcomes						
Parent joint income ($, thousands)	140.40	90.96	88.72	100.4	73.65	73.81
Associates degree or higher (%)	54.04	35.28	32.66	48.51	27.61	25.31
Bachelor's degree or higher (%)	46.42	25.33	23.18	36.68	15.89	14.25
3-year post-grad marital status (%)	52.04	28.10	28.58	63.80	23.37	22.62
5-year post-grad marital status (%)	54.45	28.89	29.50	63.91	23.90	22.86
3-year post-grad joint income ($, thousands)	106.30	61.07	55.79	109.10	42.05	39.68
5-year post-grad joint income ($, thousands)	109.80	61.94	56.41	106.60	41.16	38.78
10-year post-grad mortality (deaths per 100,000)	100	270	290	160	280	290
N (thousands)	10,310	149	78	1,370	62	36

Table 2. Estimates of the main effect of eviction filing for non-parenting students while enrolled on and the interaction effect for parenting students for all outcomes.

Outcome	Treatment	Model 1	Model 2
Associate's degree	Filed	-0.29* (-0.4, -0.18)	-0.71* (-0.83, -0.59)
	Filed*Parent	-0.31* (-0.38, -0.24)	-0.09 (-0.19, 0.02)
Bachelor's degree	Filed	-0.42* (-0.56, -0.28)	-0.79* (-0.93, -0.66)
	Filed*Parent	-0.35* (-0.44, -0.26)	-0.16* (-0.28, -0.03)
3-year post-grad joint income ($, thousands)	Filed	-47.88* (-52.58, -43.18)	-44.96* (-50.22, -39.71)
	Filed*Parent	-1.64 (-5.65, 2.38)	0.86 (-4.38, 6.1)
5-year post-grad joint income ($, thousands)	Filed	-40.73* (-43.95, -37.51)	-38.39* (-42.48, -34.29)
	Filed*Parent	-5.52* (-8.48, -2.56)	-2.89 (-7.28, 1.5)
3-year post-grad marital status (%)	Filed	-0.66* (-0.7, -0.61)	-0.51* (-0.58, -0.44)
	Filed*Parent	-0.57* (-0.66, -0.48)	-0.7* (-0.81, -0.58)
5-year post-grad marital status (%)	Filed	-0.65* (-0.69, -0.61)	-0.52* (-0.58, -0.45)
	Filed*Parent	-0.54* (-0.63, -0.45)	-0.63* (-0.75, -0.52)
10-year post-grad mortality (deaths per 100,000)	Filed	0.69* (0.57, 0.8)	0.71* (0.43, 1)
	Filed*Parent	-0.01 (-0.18, 0.15)	0.12 (-0.23, 0.47)

Note: Model 1 is the full sample with complete responses for each specific outcome, whereas Model 2 is additionally subset to respondents for whom we can observe parental income. Effect estimates are reported in log odds for binary outcomes (degree completion and mortality) and dollars for income outcomes.

Figure 1. Data linkage flowchart. All linkages are based on Protected Identification Keys (PIKs).

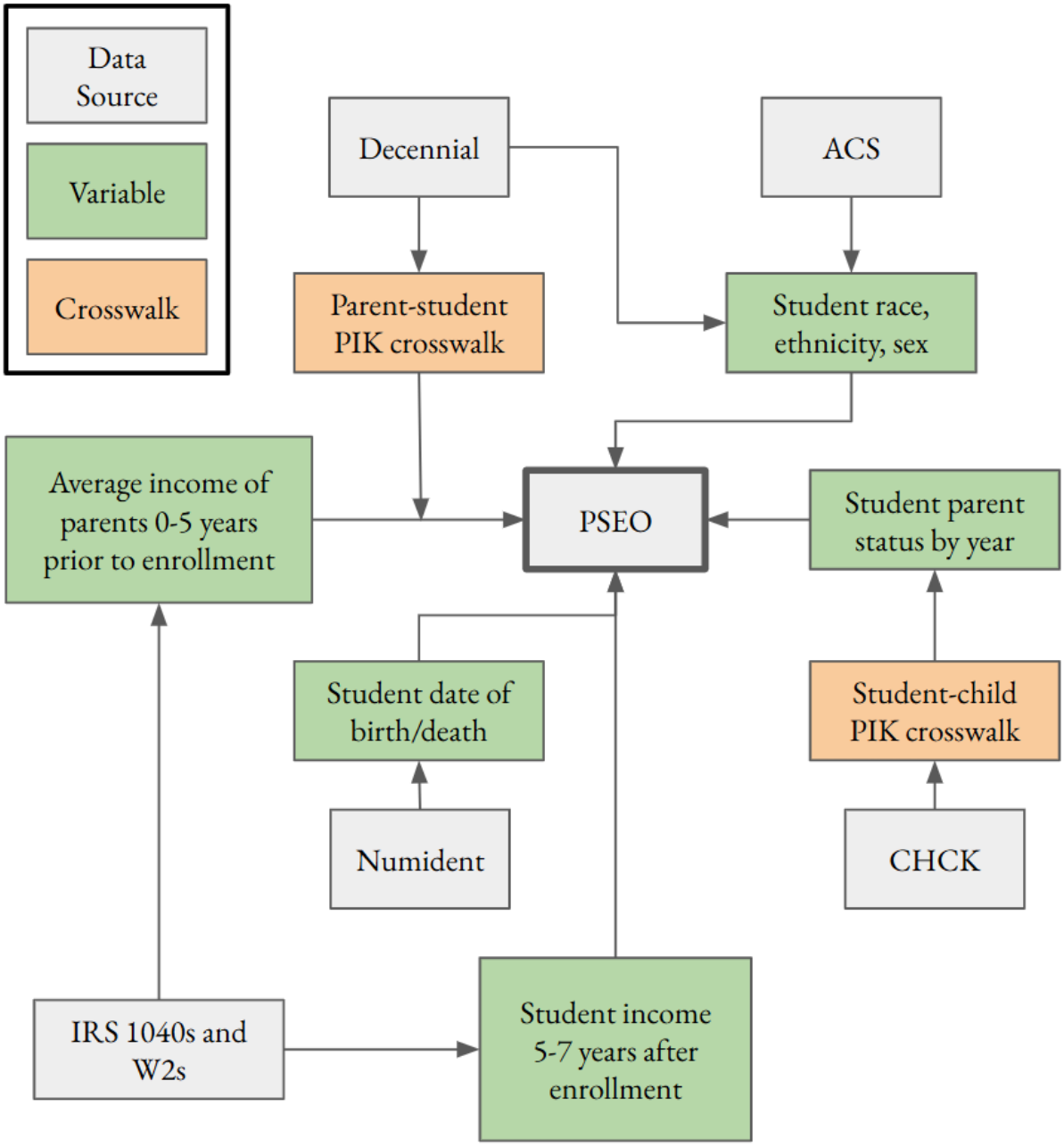


Figure 2. Average marginal predictions for all outcomes based on parenting status and filing while enrolled.

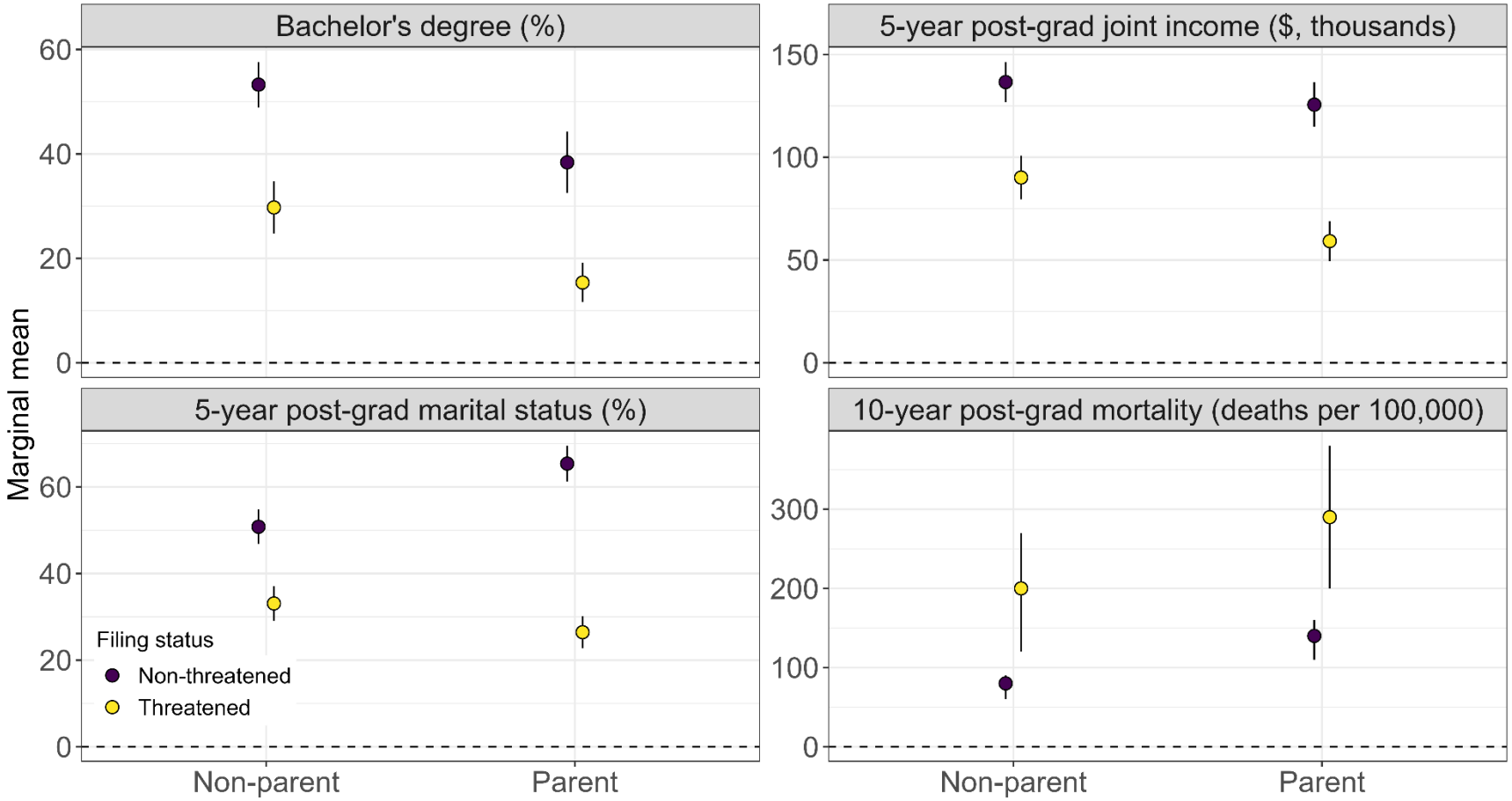


Figure 3. Estimates of interaction coefficients for the effect of filing for parenting students from models predicting 5-year post-grad joint income stratified by student age group.

